

RIGHT TO READ.
FREE LIBRARIES FOR ALL

// FISCAL FEDERALISM · CONVERGENCE · 2035

THE CONVERGENCE BLUEPRINT

A state-government-led roadmap to a tax-funded national public library network by 2035 — about 0.20% of state revenue, to the Tamil Nadu standard.

AUTHOR
THE RIGHT TO READ CAMPAIGN

SERIES
WORKING PAPERS

VERSION
V0.2.0

STATUS
DRAFT

The Convergence Blueprint

A Tax-Funded National Public Library Network by 2035

THE RIGHT TO READ CAMPAIGN

Abstract

India's consolidated public-library revenue expenditure stands at ₹5.00 real per capita in 2024–25 (see the Measurement paper). Tamil Nadu — the one state to have sustained a statutory library cess — is on track to ₹21.90 by 2034–35. This paper engineers a state-government-led convergence path to a ₹22 real-per-capita all-India target by 2035: roughly ₹3,425 crore per year of recurrent expenditure plus about ₹20,000 crore of capital expenditure to build the ~38,000 libraries the network requires — an envelope of about 0.20% of cumulative state revenue over the decade. It locates the financing in instruments that already exist (Sixteenth Finance Commission local-body grants, the SASCI library window the Centre opened in 2023–24 and closed to new projects the following year, state statutory cesses) and proposes re-integrating BharatNet, the Common Service Centres, MGNREGA-class construction, and the RRRLF into a single physical reading-commons architecture.

KEYWORDS public libraries · fiscal federalism · convergence · Finance Commission · SASCI · library cess · capital expenditure

JEL H54, H72, H77

Suggested citation

The Right to Read Campaign (2026). *The Convergence Blueprint. A Tax-Funded National Public Library Network by 2035*. Right to Read Working Paper No. 02.

Projection: Tamil Nadu’s real per-capita expenditure to 2035

Contents

1 The Re-integration Roadmap: A 0.20% Fiscal Plan	1
1.1 Recurrent expenditure (OpEx) convergence	3
1.2 Capital expenditure (CapEx): the physical infrastructure gap	3
1.3 Fiscal capacity: is this affordable?	5
1.4 Employment dividend: a construction-sector multiplier estimate	6
1.5 Sixteenth Finance Commission grants: the immediate fiscal instrument	8
1.6 Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI): the window that opened, and shut	9
1.7 Sixteenth Finance Commission monitoring infrastructure	11
1.8 What the combined number means	11
References	11

1 The Re-integration Roadmap: A 0.20% Fiscal Plan

Tamil Nadu’s real per-capita library expenditure rose from approximately ₹9.12 in 2014–15 to ₹11.72 in 2020–21 — a real CAGR of roughly 4.3%. Projected forward to 2035 at the historical rate, Tamil Nadu would spend approximately **₹21.90 per person per year (real, 2011–12 ₹)** by 2035, with bounds of [₹18.30, ₹24.40] corresponding to a real-CAGR sensitivity range of [3%, 5%]. We use square brackets to denote bounds (intervals consistent with the underlying parameter range) and reserve curly braces for confidence sets where formal statistical inference applies; the projection bounds here are scenario bounds, not confidence sets.

We adopt **₹22 per person per year (real 2011–12 ₹)** as the all-India convergence target for 2035, on the rationale set out in §5.1.

The convergence model that follows decomposes the path to this target into three integrated pillars. The first is the recurrent-expenditure (OpEx) pathway — the year-on-year spending on books, salaries, electricity, and operations needed to bring the all-India average from its 2024–25 level of approximately ₹4.89 per Indian per year (state-only; ₹5.00 consolidated state-plus-RRRLF, revenue expenditure) to ₹22. The second is the capital-expenditure (CapEx) pathway — the building, refurbishment, and digital-equipment outlay needed to close the network-density gap between current Indian library coverage and Tamil Nadu’s. The third is the *institutional* pathway — the legislative, fiscal-instrument, and coordinating-body redesign that distinguishes the Tamil Nadu trajectory from comparably-resourced states whose library systems have nonetheless collapsed under the same Centre-side pressures. Without

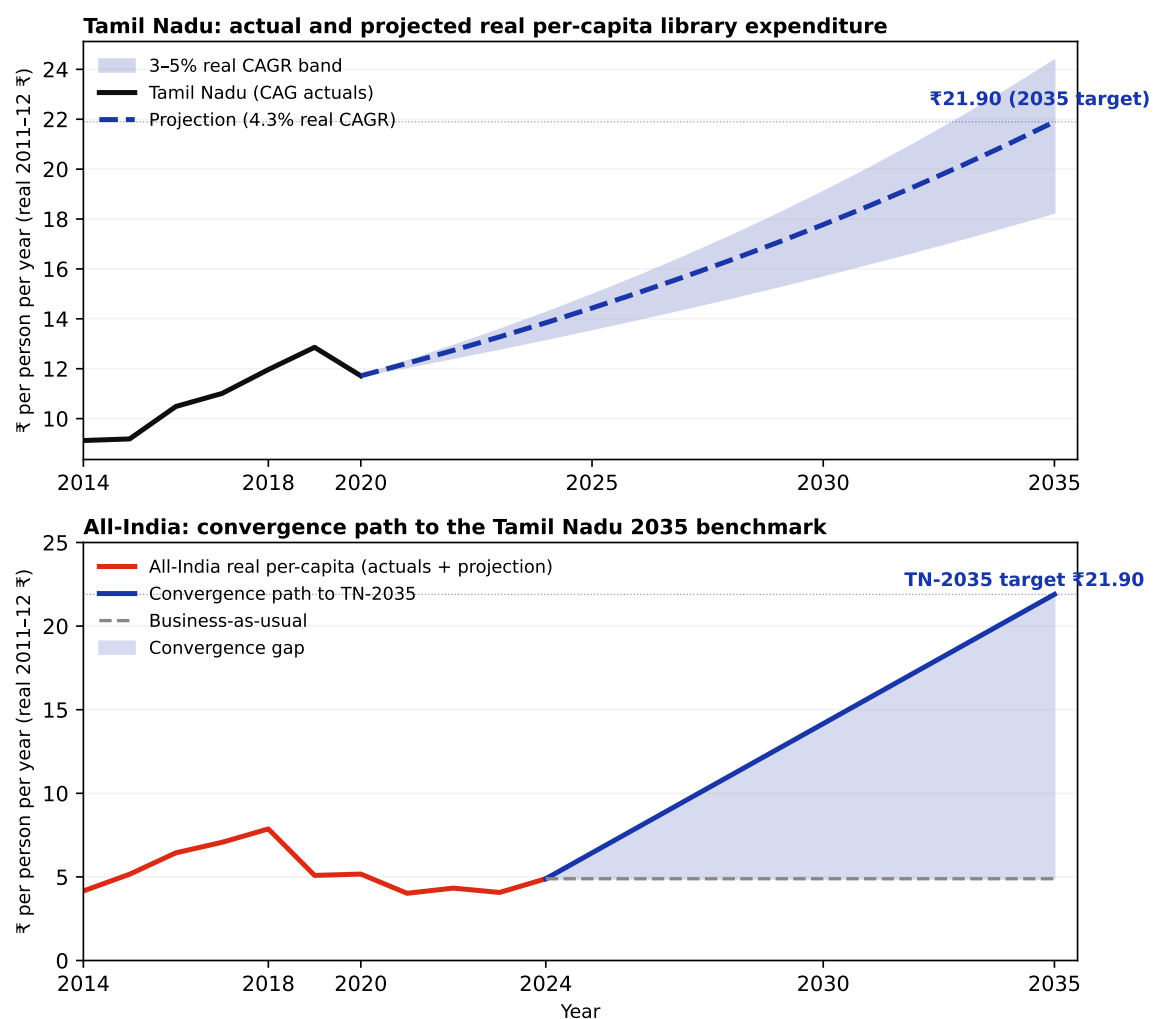


Figure 1: Tamil Nadu's projected real per-capita library expenditure to 2035 (top panel) and the corresponding all-India convergence path to the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark (bottom panel). All values in constant 2011-12 ₹.

the institutional pillar, the fiscal pillars do not hold: states that increase library expenditure without statutory protection see those gains reversed at the next budget cycle, as the cess-states' volatility documented in §3.3 demonstrates. The three pillars are independent in their financing but jointly necessary for the convergence to be durable.

1.1 Recurrent expenditure (OpEx) convergence

Table 1: Convergence fiscal arithmetic: bringing all-India real per-capita library expenditure to the projected Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark, by 2035.

Quantity	Real 2011–12 ₹
TN benchmark, 2035 real per-capita	₹21.90
All-India 2024–25 real per-capita (actual)	₹4.89
All-India 2035 target real per-capita	₹21.90
Required real annual spend, 2035 (₹ crore, 2011–12 ₹)	3,425
Current real annual spend, 2024–25 (₹ crore)	701
Annual real gap by 2035 (₹ crore)	2,660
Cumulative real additional spend, 2025–2035 (₹ crore)	15,585

The fiscal arithmetic is unsentimental. At Tamil Nadu's 2035 trajectory, all-India spending of approximately **₹3,425 crore per year (real 2011–12 ₹)** would be required by 2035 — against current real spending of approximately **₹701 crore**. The annual real gap to be closed by 2035 is therefore on the order of ₹2,660 crore. The cumulative cost of the convergence path, ramped linearly over the eleven fiscal years 2025–2035, is approximately **₹15,600 crore in real 2011–12 ₹**.

To translate to nominal future rupees, an assumed GDP-deflator growth of 4% per year would inflate this cumulative figure to roughly ₹28,000 crore in nominal terms by 2035.

1.2 Capital expenditure (CapEx): the physical infrastructure gap

Tamil Nadu's per-capita library expenditure is what it is in part because Tamil Nadu *has* libraries. The Tamil Nadu Public Library Department operates approximately 4,600 libraries across its 75 districts: one Connemara Public Library (the state central library), 32 district central libraries, branch libraries, full-time libraries, part-time libraries, and village libraries. With a population of approximately 79 million, this gives Tamil Nadu a density of roughly **one public library per 17,000 residents**. By contrast, the most-cited national-level estimate places India's public library count at approximately 54,000–70,000 — a density of approximately one per 21,000–27,000 residents, but with the deep state-level concentration that Figure 3 establishes: the four Central Zonal Council states have catastrophically few functioning libraries per capita relative to the southern and north-eastern benchmarks.

A recurrent-expenditure convergence model is incomplete because it cannot, on its own, build the network that the recurrent expenditure is supposed to operate. Bihar at ₹0.36 per person per year (real, 2018–19) cannot reach Tamil Nadu's projected 2035 standard simply by spending more on existing libraries; the libraries do not yet exist at the density required. A genuine convergence to TPL/NYPL-quality public infrastructure requires a parallel capital programme.

The state-level structure of the convergence gap is itself instructive. Figure 11 plots, for each of the thirty-one states and union territories in our cross-section, the factor by which current real per-capita library expenditure must rise to reach the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark. The distribution is severely

right-skewed: a small set of states already exceed the 2035 target, while a substantial cluster of states — the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states with low library expenditure — need increases of one to two orders of magnitude. The convergence task is geographically concentrated; FC16 grant allocations should be proportioned accordingly.

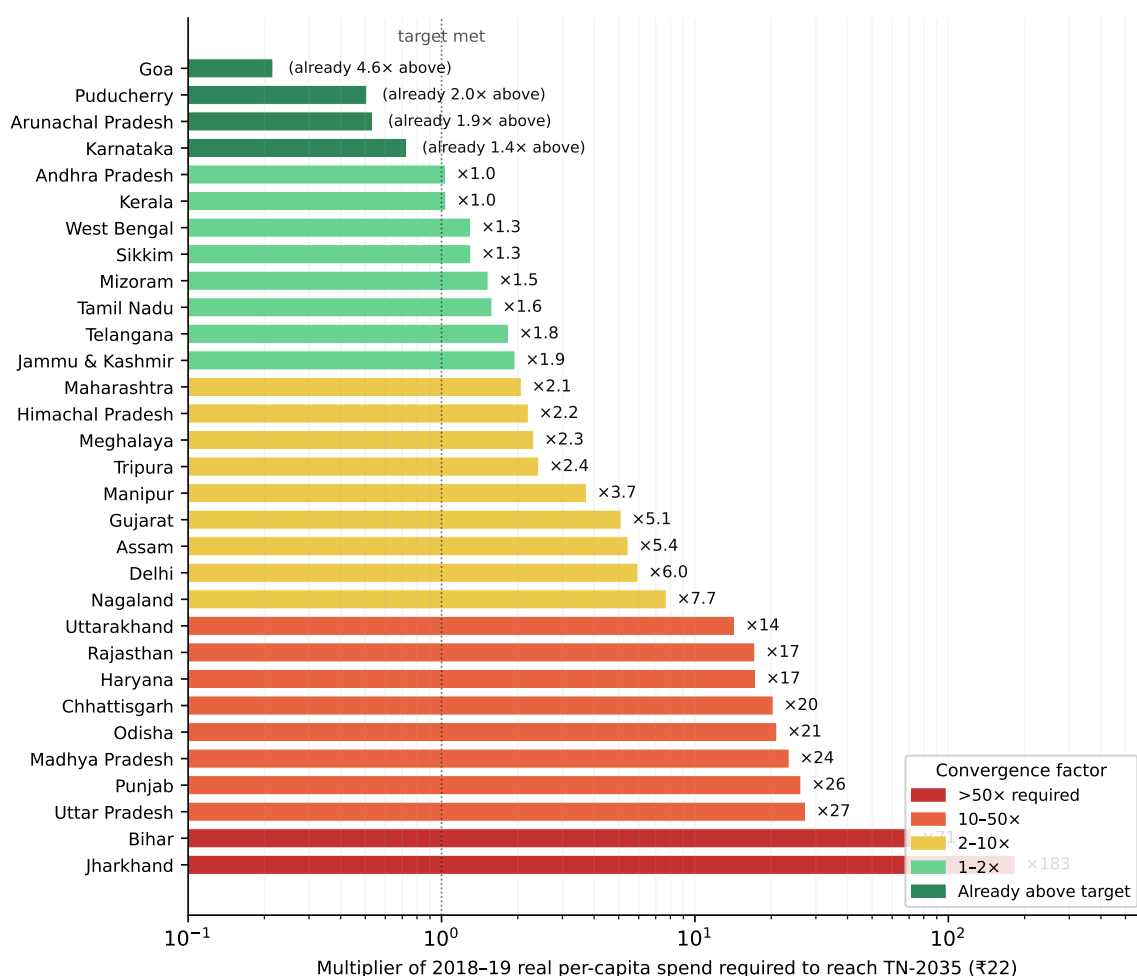


Figure 2: Factor by which each state's 2018–19 real per-capita public-library expenditure must rise to reach the Tamil Nadu 2035 benchmark (₹22 per Indian per year, real 2011–12 ₹). Log scale on x-axis. States to the left of the dotted reference line at 1.0x already exceed the 2035 target.

We provide a first-cut order-of-magnitude estimate. We do not pretend it is precise.

A genuine convergence model must account for the fact that Indian library needs are not uniform across the urban-rural spectrum or across population-served scales. Table 6 presents a six-cell typology of public library types, organised by settlement scale (urban versus rural) and by population-served category (large, mid, and small). Each cell carries its own construction-unit cost, annual operating cost, staffing model, and population-served estimate. The typology follows CPWD Plinth Area Rate norms for institutional construction and IFLA branch-library design benchmarks (Latimer and Niegaard 2007).

The portfolio weights reflect the geographic distribution of the construction gap: the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states have deep rural deficits, so small and mid rural libraries dominate the new-construction queue. Large urban libraries represent a small share of count but a disproportionate share of capex. The weighted blended cost of **₹51 lakh per new library** is derived

Table 2: Six-cell public library typology: capital and operating cost parameters (real 2011–12 Rs.). CPWD unit rates apply to Type IV institutional construction; opex is annualised recurrent expenditure including salaries, acquisitions, and utilities. Portfolio weights sum to 100% of new construction requirement.

Setting	Scale	Sqm	CPWD (Rs./sqm)	Capex (Rs. lakh)	Opex (Rs. lakh/yr)	FTE staff	Portfolio weight
Urban	Large (district/metro branch)	1,000	35,000	350	24	10	5%
Urban	Mid (neighbourhood)	250	32,000	80	7	3	12%
Urban	Small (community/mohalla)	80	28,000	22	2.5	1	8%
Rural	Large (block/taluka HQ)	500	26,000	130	11	4	8%
Rural	Mid (gram panchayat cluster)	150	22,000	33	4	1.5	22%
Rural	Small (village/hamlet)	50	18,000	9	1	0.5	45%
<i>Weighted blended capex per new library</i>							Rs. 51 lakh

directly from the cell weights and replaces the cruder three-tier approximation used in earlier versions.

Table 3: Capital expenditure (CapEx) gap-closure: building the physical library network at Tamil Nadu density by 2035.

Quantity	Value
Tamil Nadu library density (persons per library)	17,196
Current India public library count (NKC est.)	54,000
Target India library count at TN density, 2035	90,953
New libraries required, 2025–2035	36,953
Blended CapEx per new library (₹ lakh, real 2011–12)	51
Total CapEx (₹ crore, real 2011–12 ₹)	26,787
Total CapEx (₹ crore, today's 2024–25 ₹)	47,127

At Tamil Nadu's network density (approximately one library per 17,000 residents), an India of 1.56 billion people in 2035 would require approximately 92,000 public libraries. Subtracting the existing stock of approximately 54,000 leaves a construction gap of approximately 38,000 new libraries over the decade. Using the six-cell typology in Table 6 with portfolio weights reflecting the geographic distribution of the gap, the weighted blended capital cost is approximately **₹51 lakh per new library**. The implied CapEx total for new construction is on the order of **₹20,000 crore (real 2011–12 ₹)**, plus an additional **₹8,000 crore (real)** for modernisation of the existing stock.

A genuine convergence therefore requires a combined CapEx + OpEx envelope of approximately **₹44,000 crore (real 2011–12 ₹) over the decade 2025–2035**, or roughly **₹77,000 crore in nominal future-rupee terms**. The CapEx component is the larger share, and it is geographically concentrated in the four Central Zonal Council states (Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Bihar), the eastern states, and the rural areas of the western states.

1.3 Fiscal capacity: is this affordable?

The convergence cost must be located in the fiscal capacity that India's central and state governments will actually have over the decade 2025–2035. We use the consensus medium-term macro projections.

The IMF (International Monetary Fund 2025b, 2025a) projects India's real GDP growth at approximately 6.5% per annum through 2030, with the GDP deflator growing at approximately 4% per annum. The World Bank (World Bank 2025) and the Indian Ministry of Finance (Ministry of Finance,

Government of India 2025a) project consistent medium-term trajectories. We adopt **11% nominal GDP growth** as the central case; the Reserve Bank's policy framework targets a higher nominal growth band, so this is conservative.

India's combined general government revenue receipts (Centre and States, gross of inter-government transfers) were approximately ₹54 lakh crore in 2024–25 (Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2025a; Singh 2025), or approximately 18% of GDP. The IMF Article IV (International Monetary Fund 2025a) projects this ratio rising marginally over the medium term as GST and direct-tax buoyancy improves. Assuming a constant tax-to-GDP ratio (a conservative assumption — actual buoyancy is generally above unity), combined government revenue receipts would grow at the nominal GDP rate.

Cumulative combined government revenue receipts over 2025–2035, on these assumptions, are on the order of **₹950 lakh crore in nominal terms**. The convergence cost of ₹77,000 crore is therefore approximately **0.08% of cumulative government revenue over the decade**. Restricted to state-level expenditure (the Indian constitutional locus of public library funding under the Seventh Schedule), the convergence cost is approximately **0.20% of cumulative state revenue over the decade**.

Stated differently: of every ₹10,000 a state government will receive in revenue over the next decade, the convergence cost represents approximately ₹18. The figure is *trivial* in fiscal-capacity terms.

1.4 Employment dividend: a construction-sector multiplier estimate

The capital programme above is also an employment-generation programme. Construction is the second-largest absorber of unskilled labour in the Indian economy after MGNREGS, and public-construction expenditure carries documented direct, indirect, and induced employment multipliers that have been extensively estimated in the Indian context (International Labour Organization 2019; Reserve Bank of India 2026; Finance Commission of India 2021). The Employment Intensity of Investment methodology of the International Labour Organization estimates direct employment of approximately 4.5 person-years per ₹1 crore of capital expenditure in formal-and-informal-blended Indian construction. Including indirect employment (cement, steel, bricks, tile, timber, glass, and other materials supply chains) and induced employment (downstream consumption from construction wages) raises the total multiplier to approximately 10 person-years per ₹1 crore. We use these midpoints as central-case parameters; the underlying estimates carry confidence bands of approximately $\pm 20\%$ in the formal-construction segment and somewhat wider in informal segments.

Applied to the convergence CapEx of approximately ₹77,000 crore in nominal future-rupee terms over the decade 2025–2035, the implied employment dividend is in the order of **315,000 direct person-years** and **700,000 total person-years** of employment. Expressed as steady-state employment sustained across the construction decade, this is approximately **31,500 workers in direct construction employment** and **70,000 workers across the full economic footprint of the programme, sustained year-on-year across the decade**.

By way of scale reference: the rural employment guarantee architecture under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, 2005 (MGNREGA) operated at 200–250 crore person-days per year (approximately 65–80 million person-year equivalents annually) (Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India 2024). MGNREGA was a *rights-based* programme: any adult member of a rural household had a justiciable legal right to 100 days of waged manual work per year, with unemployment allowance owed by the state if work was not provided within fifteen days of

demand. From 1 July 2026 it has been formally superseded by the Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 (The Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 2025), which preserves the language of guarantee while diluting its substance: the new framework caps days at 125 *per household* (not per adult), shifts the cost share from the MGNREGA convention (100% Centre for wages, 75:25 for materials) to a 60:40 Centre-State formula, and re-anchors the architecture from a rights-based welfare floor to a scheme-based deliverable under the “Viksit Bharat” political-economic frame. The 2025 Act is, in substance, a dilution of the rights-based architecture of 2005 carried out under bureaucratic-succession framing. We name this explicitly because the comparison the library CapEx programme makes against this comparator must respect what the comparator now is.

The library CapEx programme is roughly one-tenth of the rural employment guarantee’s aggregate scale. The comparison is for calibration of relative magnitude, not for substitution between programmes and not for co-financing. The rural employment guarantee, in either its 2005 or 2025 form, funds daily-rated wage employment on a seasonal basis; the library programme generates *durable physical infrastructure* — a fixed asset in the public domain. The two are distinct fiscal categories with distinct rights claims and should not be merged. In particular, we do not recommend classifying library construction as employment-guarantee work under VB-G RAM G’s “rural infrastructure” domain. Funding public-library construction through a diluted-rights employment scheme would (i) further weaken the rights-based architecture of rural waged work by making it carry investment categories it was not designed to finance, and (ii) leave library construction itself politically exposed to the same dilution pathway. The library CapEx envelope should be financed through the dedicated fiscal instruments named in §6 (Sixteenth Finance Commission grants, SASCI sub-tranche, state-level statutory cesses), not by absorbing into a diluted employment guarantee.

A second-order consideration is the green-jobs increment. The IPCC Sixth Assessment Report’s chapter on buildings (Cabeza et al. 2022) documents that low-carbon construction methods — compressed-earth blocks substituting for cement masonry; fly-ash cement substituting for Portland cement; bamboo, locally-sourced stone, and engineered timber substituting for energy-intensive imports; passive solar design substituting for active cooling — generate approximately 1.5 times the direct employment per rupee of capital deployed, because the substituted materials are labour-intensive rather than energy-intensive in their production. The UNEP International Resource Panel’s buildings-sector analysis (UNEP International Resource Panel 2020) is directionally consistent. At a 50% adoption rate for low-carbon materials across the new-library construction programme — itself a conservative assumption relative to GRIHA / IGBC ratings now standard in public construction tenders — the green-jobs increment is approximately **40,000 additional direct person-years** over the decade, or approximately **4,000 additional steady-state workers** in low-carbon materials manufacturing, processing, and on-site application.

Combining the construction and green-jobs estimates, the convergence CapEx supports approximately **35,000 to 40,000 direct construction-sector jobs sustained across the decade**, with a full employment multiplier of approximately **75,000 jobs** across the supply chain and consumption-induced channels. These are durable, geographically-distributed, and skill-graded jobs — concentrated in precisely the states (the four Central Zonal Council states and the eastern states) where the library-density gap is widest and where construction-sector employment is itself a developmental priority.

The construction unit-cost assumptions underlying these scenarios are consistent with the Central

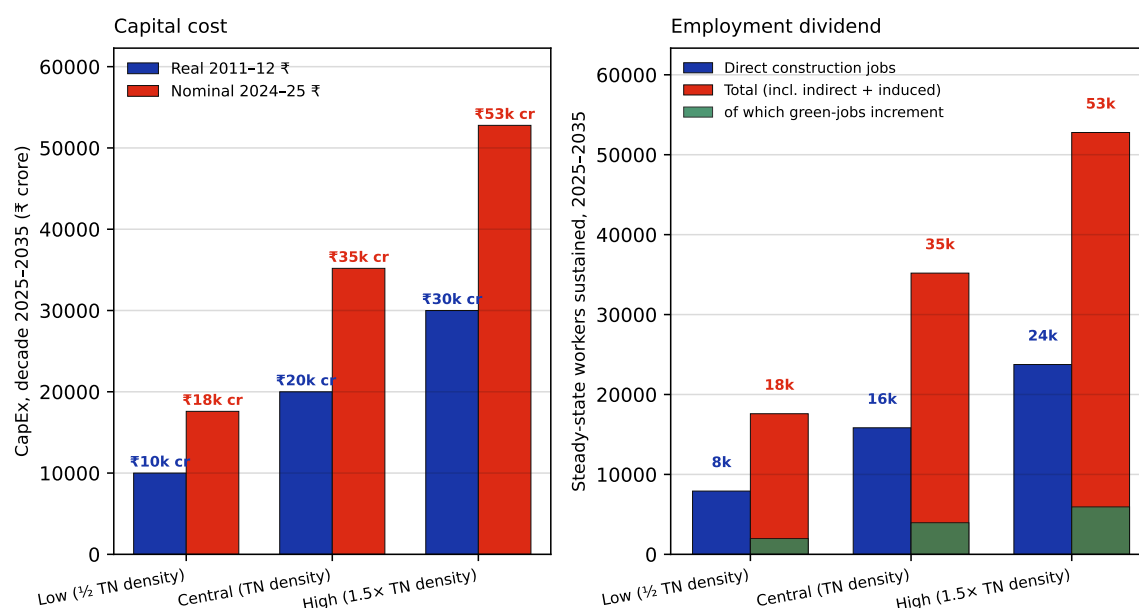


Figure 3: Three-scenario sensitivity for the public-library CapEx programme, 2025–2035. Low scenario: 50% of TN density (~19,000 new libraries; ₹10,000 crore real). Central scenario: TN density (~38,000 new libraries; ₹20,000 crore real). High scenario: 150% of TN density (~57,000 new libraries; ₹30,000 crore real). Bars show person-years of direct and total employment sustained across the decade; cost-to-Union-Budget share noted under each scenario.

Public Works Department's Plinth Area Rates for institutional buildings (Type IV) at the latest CPWD notification, which sit in the range of ₹28,000 to ₹35,000 per square metre of built-up area for institutional construction including basic IT and electrical fit-out. The blended ₹51 lakh per new library is derived from a portfolio of approximately 100 square metres for village/branch libraries, 250 square metres for taluka libraries, and 1,000 square metres for district libraries, weighted by population coverage. Per-square-metre sizing follows international library-design benchmarks (Latimer and Niegaard 2007). State PWD rates vary by approximately $\pm 15\%$ around CPWD baselines; sensitivity to this variation is incorporated in the low/high scenario bands.

1.5 Sixteenth Finance Commission grants: the immediate fiscal instrument

The fiscal-capacity argument is sharpened by the Sixteenth Finance Commission's award, tabled in Parliament on 1 February 2026 (Sixteenth Finance Commission, Government of India 2026). The Commission has recommended grants of approximately **₹7.9 lakh crore to India's local bodies over the five-year period 2026–27 to 2030–31**, comprising ₹4.4 lakh crore for Rural Local Bodies and ₹3.6 lakh crore for Urban Local Bodies. Of these grants, 80% are basic and 20% performance-linked; the basic component is further split half tied (to drinking water, sanitation, and solid-waste management) and half untied.

A back-of-envelope locates the convergence cost within this fiscal instrument. The first five years of the convergence path — roughly half of the cumulative ₹77,000 crore in today's terms — is approximately **₹38,500 crore over 2026–27 to 2030–31**. As a share of the Sixteenth Finance Commission's local-body award, this is approximately **4.9%**. As a share of the *untied* component of the basic grant (50% of 80% of ₹7.9 lakh crore = ₹3.16 lakh crore), it is approximately **12%**. Recommendations 5–8 of §7 below are therefore actionable within the existing FC16 grant architecture: nothing additional is required at

the Centre. What is required is a sub-classification of the untied basic grant — or a new tied category alongside water and sanitation — for public-library expenditure at the local-body level. The fiscal instrument is in place. The allocative decision is not.

1.6 Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI): the window that opened, and shut

The Sixteenth Finance Commission grant architecture, however, is not the only central capex instrument relevant to library infrastructure. Under the Fifteenth Finance Commission framework (2021–26), the Government of India has progressively shifted central transfers from untied Finance Commission grants toward conditional, sector-tied capital schemes. The principal vehicle is the **Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI)** scheme — 50-year interest-free loans from the Centre to state governments for capital infrastructure, operating at approximately ₹1.5 lakh crore per year (Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2025b).

Libraries are not missing from that instrument. They were written into it. **Part-VII of the Scheme for Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment 2023–24 is “Children and Adolescents’ Libraries and Digital Infrastructure”** (Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2024). The Centre did not fail to think of libraries as capital investment; it designated a dedicated library window, named it, and funded projects under it. The allocative decision was taken. What happened next is the finding.

Two state records document what the window financed. In **Goa**, the Info Tech Corporation of Goa records ₹74.70 crore under “Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment 2023–24” for 78 newly constructed Gram Panchayat libraries, 79 renovated Panchayat buildings and 11 municipal buildings converted into learning spaces, each of “compact and efficient layouts of up to 500 sq. ft.” and digital-ready (Info Tech Corporation of Goa Limited, Government of Goa 2024). That is 168 facilities for ₹74.70 crore, or **₹44.46 lakh per facility** in nominal 2023–24 ₹. The figure is not directly comparable to the blended ₹51 lakh per new library used above, which is expressed in real 2011–12 ₹ and covers new construction only: 90 of Goa’s 168 facilities are conversions of existing panchayat and municipal buildings, and a nominal 2023–24 rupee is worth about 0.57 of a real 2011–12 rupee at this paper’s deflator. What Goa establishes is narrower and still useful — that a state government could deliver library floor space under this window at a unit cost of the same order as the one assumed here, and did.

In **Karnataka**, the Economic Survey 2025–26 records that 6,599 new libraries are being started under the same Central programme, “Children and Adolescents Libraries and Digital Infrastructure” within the Scheme for Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment. For each library the state purchased six copies of 340 Kannada titles and three copies of 209 English titles at **₹2 lakh per library**, and furniture at **₹1 lakh per library** (Planning, Programme Monitoring and Statistics Department, Government of Karnataka 2026, 146). The arithmetic is ₹131.98 crore of books and ₹65.99 crore of furniture: **₹197.97 crore** on the state’s own published figures. Press reporting adds a further ₹65.99 crore for computers and UPS systems, taking the package to ₹263.96 crore, or ₹4 lakh per library; we treat that third component as secondary evidence pending the Cabinet order.

The two states describe two different models, and the difference matters for costing. Goa built rooms at ₹44.46 lakh each. Karnataka fitted out rooms it already had — unused classrooms, community

buildings, old anganwadis, panchayat buildings — at ₹3 lakh each on primary evidence. A national programme would need both, and the second is roughly fifteen times cheaper per library than the first. Karnataka's SASCI package is additional to, not a substitute for, its existing cess-supported Arivu Kendra network; the two are distinct layers and should not be netted against each other.

Then the Centre shut the window. The guidelines for 2024–25 create a Part-II carrying ₹5,000 crore for the release of *balance* funds against projects already approved in 2023–24 under Part-V (police housing), Part-VI (unity malls) and Part-VII (libraries). The operative sentence is unambiguous: **“However, no new capital projects will be approved under this Part.”** In the same document, in the same year, Part-III — Development of Iconic Tourist Centres to Global Scale — is earmarked a fresh ₹5,000 crore (Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2024). Same scheme, same fiscal year, same signature: tourism receives new money; libraries are wound down to the settlement of outstanding bills.

The wind-down is still running. The 2026–27 guidelines (F. No. 44(1)/PF-S/2026-27) again list “Children and Adolescent Libraries and Digital Infrastructure” — but only among five categories sharing ₹5,000 crore of *balance* funds for already-approved projects, alongside unity malls, police housing, iconic tourist centres and working women's hostels (Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India 2026). That ₹5,000 crore is not a library allocation and must not be cited as one. Three years after Part-VII opened, the Centre is still closing it out, and has not reopened it.

This changes the shape of the ask. The obstacle is not that the Union government has never conceived of public libraries as capital investment — it has, recently, and in its own scheme architecture. The obstacle is **duration**: a library window open for one year, against a tourism window renewed with fresh money the next. A capital programme that closes to new projects after twelve months cannot build a network; it can only produce a scatter of demonstration sites, which is precisely what Goa and Karnataka are. The estimated CapEx requirement for an all-India Tamil-Nadu-density network (₹20,000 crore real, ₹35,000 crore nominal) is approximately **2.3% of one year's SASCI envelope**, spread over a decade. The instrument, the designation, the disbursement machinery and the state-level absorptive capacity are all demonstrated. What is missing is a Part-VII that stays open.

Two limits on this finding should be stated. First, we have not obtained the Department of Expenditure's **2023–24** guidelines, so Part-VII's original allocation is unverified; figures circulating in secondary summaries are not used here. Second, no consolidated Central state-wise list of Part-VII sanctions is in the public record. Goa and Karnataka can be named because their own governments published the detail; the national total cannot yet be stated, and a parliamentary question remains the route to it.

The Ministry of Culture's own framing sits alongside this. Answering in the Lok Sabha on 11 August 2025 on cultural-development assistance to Bihar (Ministry of Culture and Tourism, Government of India 2025), the Ministry enumerated seven mandate areas — “Archaeological sites, Museums and its artefacts, **Public Libraries**, Promotion and dissemination of Performing Arts, Buddhist and Tibetan studies, International Cultural Relation and construction of cultural complexes” — and named SASCI alongside Swadesh Darshan (SD and SD 2.0), Challenge Based Destination Development (CBDD), Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual, Heritage Augmentation Drive (PRASHAD) and Assistance to Central Agencies (ACA) as the central capex pipes for the domain. The projects the answer then lists for Bihar are tourism and heritage destinations — Karamchat Eco-Tourism Hub (₹49.51 crore

sanctioned), Saharsa Matsyagandha Lake Development (₹97.61 crore sanctioned), ₹147.12 crore for two sites. That annexure is scoped to one state and cannot support a claim about library funding nationally. What it does show is that libraries sit inside the enumerated mandate of the ministry whose capital pipes flow, at this scale, to destinations.

For state governments planning library investment, the consequence is a timing problem rather than a permanent exclusion. The state-government-led convergence path established in §5.1–§5.5 holds independently of any SASCI reopening. But a Part-VII reopened for new projects, and held open across a Finance Commission cycle rather than a single budget, would compress the network build-out from a decade to five-to-seven years and free state borrowing headroom for other priorities.

1.7 Sixteenth Finance Commission monitoring infrastructure

That such an allocative decision is plausible is supported by the parallel architecture for monitoring it. The Ministry of Panchayati Raj's Panchayat Advancement Index portal (pai.gov.in), built on the eGramSwaraj data platform, already tracks a basket of infrastructure indicators at gram-panchayat level, including the existence of panchayat library facilities. The data infrastructure required to operationalise both grant disbursement (against verified panchayat-level library investment) and outcome monitoring (against verified library service provision) is therefore already partially in place. It requires only that the relevant ministries — Panchayati Raj, Culture, and Education — be authorised by the Finance Ministry to use it for this purpose.

1.8 What the combined number means

The combined envelope — recurrent expenditure to bring all-India per-capita library spending to the projected Tamil Nadu 2035 standard, plus capital expenditure to build the physical network at Tamil Nadu density — is approximately **₹44,000 crore in real 2011–12 ₹**, or **₹77,000 crore in nominal terms**, over the decade 2025–2035. Figure 7 places this envelope alongside three reference quantities of Indian public finance. Located in the actual fiscal accounts of the Indian state:

#| label: fig-context #| fig-cap: “Decade-cumulative convergence cost (₹77,000 crore nominal) in the context of comparable Indian public expenditure quantities. Convergence cost is one decade; the comparators are single-year fiscal flows or one-off capital outlays. Log scale.” #| fig-width: 7 #| fig-height: 3.2

```
bench = [ ("Library convergence (decade total)", 70_000, C_RED), ("Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train
(capital outlay)", 1_10_000, C_BLUE), ("Central defence (one year, 2024-25)", 6_15_000, C_GREY),
("States' social-sector expenditure (one year)", 17_00_000, C_INK),] labels = [b[0] for b in bench]
values = [b[1] for b in bench] colors = [b[2] for b in bench]
```

```
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(7, 3.2)) bars = ax.barh(labels, values, color=colors, height=0.65, edge-
color='white', lw=0.5) for bar, v in zip(bars, values): ax.text(v * 1.05, bar.get_y() + bar.get_height()/2,
f'₹{v/100000:.2f} lakh cr',
```

References

Cabeza, L. F., Q. Bai, P. Bertoldi, et al. 2022. *Buildings*. Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, Sixth Assessment Report, Working Group III.

Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India. 2024. *Scheme for Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment 2024-25: Guidelines*. Public Finance–States Division, Government of India.

Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India. 2026. *Scheme for Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment 2026-27: Guidelines*. F. No. 44(1)/PF-S/2026-27 (CAPEX), Government of India.

Finance Commission of India. 2021. *Finance Commission in COVID Times: Report for 2021–26*. Fifteenth Finance Commission, Government of India.

Info Tech Corporation of Goa Limited, Government of Goa. 2024. *Construction of New Libraries and Renovation of Existing Buildings Towards Setting up of Libraries for Children and Adolescents with Digital Infrastructure Across the State of Goa*. Project record, <https://infotech.goa.gov.in/projects/new/construction-of-new-libraries>.

International Labour Organization. 2019. *Employment Intensity of Investment: An Updated Estimation Methodology for India*. ILO Decent Work Country Programme, India.

International Monetary Fund. 2025a. *India: 2025 Article IV Consultation Staff Report*. International Monetary Fund.

International Monetary Fund. 2025b. *World Economic Outlook: Policy Pivot, Rising Threats*. International Monetary Fund.

Latimer, Karen, and Hellen Niegaard. 2007. *IFLA Library Building Guidelines: Developments and Reflections*. De Gruyter Saur.

Ministry of Culture and Tourism, Government of India. 2025. *Lok Sabha Unstarred Question No. 3667: Financial Assistance for Development of Culture in Bihar*. Answered by Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Minister of Culture and Tourism, Lok Sabha.

Ministry of Finance, Government of India. 2025a. *Economic Survey 2024–25*. Government of India.

Ministry of Finance, Government of India. 2025b. *Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI)*. Department of Expenditure, scheme initiative.

Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India. 2024. *Outcome Budget 2024-25: Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme*. MGNREGS Division, Ministry of Rural Development.

Planning, Programme Monitoring and Statistics Department, Government of Karnataka. 2026. *Economic Survey of Karnataka 2025-26*. Government of Karnataka.

Reserve Bank of India. 2026. *State Finances: A Study of Budgets of 2025–26*. Reserve Bank of India.

Singh, Shruti. 2025. *State of State Finances 2025*. PRS Legislative Research.

Sixteenth Finance Commission, Government of India. 2026. *Report of the Sixteenth Finance Commission for the Period 2026–27 to 2030–31*. Government of India.

The Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 (2025).

UNEP International Resource Panel. 2020. *Resource Efficiency and Climate Change: Material Efficiency Strategies for a Low-Carbon Future*. United Nations Environment Programme.

World Bank. 2025. *India Development Update: Navigating a Resilient Recovery*. World Bank.